Replaying 'Kingdom Hearts': A Fan Misses the Final Fantasy Friends

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The video game website Kotaku is replaying the whole 'Kingdom Hearts' **series** over a year in a kind of book club called Guiding Key. The next main game, 'Kingdom Hearts IV,' is expected in about a year. In the latest entry, the writer looks back at how the first game brought in characters from the 'Final Fantasy' **series**.

'Kingdom Hearts' is a **crossover** that mixes Disney characters like Donald Duck and Goofy with heroes from 'Final Fantasy,' a long-running **role-playing game series**. The main hero is a boy named Sora.

The writer explains that when they first played as a kid, they did not even know some characters came from 'Final Fantasy.' Now, after playing many 'Final Fantasy' games, they notice much more.

On Sora's home, Destiny Islands, his friends include Tidus and Wakka from 'Final Fantasy X' and Selphie from 'Final Fantasy VIII.' They are younger than in their own games and use playground **versions** of their weapons. Tidus swings a wooden practice sword, and Selphie uses a jump rope.

In Traverse Town, a safe place for people whose worlds are disappearing, Sora meets more familiar faces, including Leon, Yuffie and Aerith. The writer says these characters feel much closer to their original **versions**. They also enjoy the funny first meeting between Sora, Donald and Goofy, and the town's music.

The writer's main point is that 'Final Fantasy' characters have played a smaller and smaller part in later games. 'Kingdom Hearts III' did not include any until extra **content** was added. The writer wonders whether newer 'Final Fantasy' heroes might appear in 'Kingdom Hearts IV.'

Word Treasure

crossover -- A story or game that brings together characters from different series.

role-playing game -- A game where you control characters, go on quests and help them grow stronger.

versions -- Different forms of the same thing.

content -- Material such as levels, stories or characters added to a game.

series -- A set of related games, books or shows that come one after another.

Background you need

'Kingdom Hearts' is a video game series made by Square Enix together with Disney.

Players travel to different worlds based on Disney movies while meeting characters from Square Enix's 'Final Fantasy' role-playing games.

Fans sometimes replay a whole series before a new game comes out to remember the story and notice details they missed.

Many games now add extra content after release, called downloadable content.

Break it down

LEAD: Kotaku's year-long 'Kingdom Hearts' replay looks at the first game's 'Final Fantasy' characters

KEY POINT: The writer notices much more now after playing many 'Final Fantasy' games

+- DESTINY ISLANDS: Tidus, Wakka and Selphie appear younger with playground weapons

+- TRAVERSE TOWN: Leon, Yuffie and Aerith feel close to their originals

ARGUMENT: 'Final Fantasy' characters have shrunk in later games; 'Kingdom Hearts III' had none until extra content

OPEN QUESTION: Will newer 'Final Fantasy' heroes appear in 'Kingdom Hearts IV'?

Why it matters

The column shows how fans think about crossovers and what they hope to see in the next game, which is expected in about a year.

Test what you remember

1. What is Kotaku doing with the 'Kingdom Hearts' series?

- (A) Replaying the whole series over a year
- (B) Reviewing only 'Kingdom Hearts IV'
- (C) Selling old copies
- (D) Making a new game

2. Which two worlds of characters does 'Kingdom Hearts' mix?

- (A) Marvel and DC
- (B) Pokemon and Mario
- (C) Disney and 'Final Fantasy'
- (D) Star Wars and Disney

3. Who is the main hero of 'Kingdom Hearts'?

- (A) Tidus
- (B) Sora
- (C) Leon
- (D) Goofy

4. What does Selphie use instead of her usual weapon on Destiny Islands?

- (A) A jump rope
- (B) A wooden sword
- (C) A ball
- (D) A magic wand

5. How does the writer say Leon, Yuffie and Aerith compare with their original versions?

- (A) They do not speak
- (B) They are much younger
- (C) They feel much closer to their original versions
- (D) They are completely different

6. What is the writer's main point?

- (A) Disney characters should be removed
- (B) 'Kingdom Hearts IV' is cancelled
- (C) 'Final Fantasy' characters have played a smaller part in later games
- (D) The music is too loud

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Kotaku writer: Wishes the series would again feature 'Final Fantasy' characters as much as the first game did.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):